Fiji. These problems led to growing calls to end the indenture system, spearheaded by Gandhi's close associate, Charles Freer Andrews, who true to his name, campaigned vigorously to free the Indians from the perils of indentured labour.[17]

In the early 20th century, Punjabi and Gujarati agriculturalists and traders arrived as free migrants, adding to the Indian diversity in Fiji. The Indo-Fijians began to cultivate their own sugar and identity and moved to other occupations. However, unlike the Caribbean and Mascarene worlds, interaction between the Indians and the native Fijians was minimal and regulated by the government through a native policy. The growing prominence of the Indo-Fijians inevitably caused friction with the native Fijians and these have persisted till date. Fiji gained independence in 1970 but slid into periodic bouts of turbulence with growing cries of 'Fiji for Fijians' and the severe harassment of Indo-Fijians after a coup in 1987 and more recently in 2006. While the Indo-Fijians still make up a third of the local population, many have fled to Australia, New Zealand, Canada and other countries. Brij V. Lal, a Girmitiya descendant and an Indo-Fijian academic who edited the seminal *Encylopedia of the Indian Diaspora*, was one such person expelled from Fiji for voicing his views.

From Fiji to Jamaica, the Indian world in overseas sugar plantations has had a varied experience. In all places, Indians experienced upward mobility as they began to move out of plantations, and in all places the economic performance of the destination countries was greater than the source region. Yet, this process was associated with challenges of racial conflict with other groups, similar to what the Indians faced in South East Asia, albeit on a far greater scale.

The Land of Gold: South East Asia

The greatest influence of cultures evolving in the Indian subcontinent has undoubtedly been on South East Asia. It is here that you see temples, mosques and shrines with a distinct Indian flavour owing to cross-cultural encounters over a period spanning millennia. It is here that an Indian